so too definitions – of values and ideals – had to keep an open-ended character: meanings were not stipulative, but needed to be worked out in the crucible of practice. In his own life, and in his recounting of it, he bore witness to this. The persona adopted in *An Autobiography* is not that of a saintly, prophetic individual preaching his message; rather, it is that of a kind of Everyman (one of Gandhi's favourite books was Bunyan's *Pilgrim's Progress*), stumbling painfully out from darkness and error towards the light of truth. Gandhi charts out an artisanal picture of the moral self – one that enables the crafting of an ethics at once personal and universal, in the midst of a bewildering world.

That ethics was far removed from any Hindu view of a spiritual life as one that required renunciation of the world. Gandhi, at the close of his *Autobiography*, explained the relationship between his spiritual quest, his pursuit of truth by means of *Ahimsa* or non-violence, and his involvement in public life:

> To see the universal and all-pervading Spirit of Truth face to face, one must be able to love the meanest of creation as oneself. And a man who aspires after that cannot afford to keep out of any field of life. That is why my devotion to Truth has drawn me into the field of politics; and I can say without the slightest hesitation, and yet in all humility, that those who say that religion has nothing to do with politics do not know what religion means.

It is an important formulation, and one which makes no sense if read either solely in terms of the grammar of traditional Hinduism, or the lexicon of modern politics. By putting it this way, Gandhi steers our attention to the profound unconventionality of his ethical sense: its existence as a product of radical, original, and deeply personal choice. The necessity of